THE CLAUDE SETUP PLAYBOOK

Embed your business into Claude properly. In under an hour.

A Leaderize resource April 2026

This playbook is for business owners setting up Claude properly for the first time, or auditing a rushed setup. It covers the four layers Claude gives you to embed your context, and shows you what goes where - with fill-in templates and two worked examples (one single business, one multi-business).

Read it end-to-end once. Then use the templates. **Total setup time: 45 to 60 minutes.**

HOW THIS WORKS IN PRACTICE

You set each layer up ONCE inside Claude's settings. After that, Claude loads them automatically each time you start a new chat. You do not need to re-paste your preferences into conversations.

Think of it like the keyboard settings on your phone. You set 'autocorrect to UK or US spelling' once, and every app uses either UK/US spelling from then on. Same here - except the settings are richer, and Claude uses them to shape every response.

In this playbook you will set up the four layers in order. Then you use Claude as you have been. The layers do the work silently in the background.

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1. The four layers of Claude

Claude gives you four places to store context about yourself and your work. Most people only use the chat box. That is the equivalent of re-introducing yourself to a colleague every single morning.

Each layer has a specific job. Use them in order.

The mental model

Profile Preferences = the operating system.

Memory = the notes Claude takes about you as you work.

Projects = the apps running on it.

Styles = the font and spacing you prefer to read in.

The four layers at a glance

Layer	What it is	What goes here	What does NOT go here
Profile Preferences	Global. Claude loads this automatically in every chat.	Who you are. How you work. Your communication style. Behaviour rules.	Specific business details. Idea Client. Brand guidelines.
Memory	Auto-generated summary of your chats. Available to all users since 2 March 2026.	Nothing, by you, directly. Claude builds it from your conversations. You review and edit.	Confidential client data. Regulated information. Sensitive personal details.
Projects	A dedicated workspace. Claude uses this context only inside that Project.	One per business, client, or recurring workstream. Own instructions and files.	Your universal working style (that belongs in Preferences).
Styles	How Claude formats and delivers responses.	Voice presets: concise, formal, explanatory. Custom style from your writing samples.	Facts about you or your business. Rules or constraints.

Where to find each layer in Claude

The diagram below shows where each layer lives in the Claude interface, and what you actually do in each one. Set them up in this order.

The Claude Setup Map

Set up once. Claude does the rest.

1 PROFILE PREFERENCES	2 MEMORY	3 PROJECTS	4 STYLES
Where to find it: **Settings → Profile**	Where to find it: **Settings → Memory**	Where to find it: **Left sidebar → + New Project**	Where to find it: **Chat window → Style selector** (near chat box)
What you do: **Write who you are and your working rules, once.**	What you do: **Review what Claude remembers. Edit or delete as needed.**	What you do: **Create one per business. Add instructions and files.**	What you do: **Pick a preset or upload your writing samples.**
Loads into every chat automatically.	*Auto-builds as you chat. You supervise it.*	*Claude uses this context only inside that Project.*	*Optional. Switch anytime.*

Set these up in this order. Total time: 45 to 60 minutes.

Your setup order — do these four things, in this sequence

1. **Profile Preferences -** Settings → Profile. Paste your preferences in. 5 minutes.
2. **Memory -** Settings → Memory. Check what Claude already knows. Edit or delete anything wrong. 5 minutes.
3. **Projects -** Left sidebar → + New Project. Create one per business. Add instructions and upload knowledge files. 20-30 minutes.
4. **Styles (optional) -** In any chat window. Pick a preset or upload a writing sample. 5 minutes.

2. Single business vs multiple businesses

This is the most important decision you will make during setup. Getting it wrong creates friction. Getting it right means Claude adapts to whichever business you are in without you re-explaining.

The core principle

If your business identity lives in Profile Preferences, every conversation inherits it. That is brilliant for a single-business owner. It is a problem for a multi-business owner, because Claude will drag Business A's context into Business B's work.

Question	Single-business owner	Multi-business owner
Where does your business identity live?	Profile Preferences. Safe to include.	Inside each Project. Keep Preferences business-neutral.
How many Projects?	One Project per workstream (e.g. launch, content, sales).	One Project per business minimum. Sub-projects for workstreams inside each.
Biggest risk to avoid	Overcrowding one Project with too many files.	Cross-contamination. Claude referencing Business A while you work on Business B.
How to use Memory safely	Let it build. Review quarterly to ensure accuracy.	Use Incognito for business-specific chats, OR review Memory weekly to catch cross-over.
What belongs in Preferences	Role, industry, audience, tone, behaviour rules.	Only things true across ALL your ventures: how you think, challenge preferences, language standard.

Quick Check

If you switched businesses tomorrow, how much of your Preferences would still apply?

If the answer is ‘most of it’, you are a single-business owner for setup purposes.

If the answer is ‘half at best’, you are multi-business. Set up accordingly.

2.5 Memory: the layer you cannot ignore

Added as of April 2026. This section is essential for multi-business owners.

As of 2 March 2026, Claude automatically generates Memory from your chat history (Anthropic, 2026c). This is available on every plan including the free tier. It runs in the background, building a profile of your preferences, recurring topics, and working style - whether you set it up or not.

Memory is powerful. For a multi-business owner, it is also the single biggest source of cross-contamination risk.

What Memory actually does

- Scans your chat history automatically (not Projects by default - those have their own separate memory space)
- Builds a summary profile about you: role, preferences, writing style, recurring themes
- Surfaces that profile in every new standalone conversation
- Updates within 24 hours when you create, modify, or delete conversations

Where to find and control it

Settings → Memory. Three things you can do:

- View what Claude currently remembers about you
- Edit or delete individual memories
- Turn off ‘Generate memory from chat history’ entirely

The multi-business problem

Memory builds from all your standalone chats combined. If you spent Monday working on Business A and Tuesday on Business B, Claude’s Memory will contain traces of both - and may surface Business A language while you are working on Business B.

Three ways to manage it

OPTION 1 — Work inside Projects as much as possible

Project chats have their own separate memory space, isolated from your standalone chat Memory. This is the cleanest solution for multi-business owners. Anything business-specific goes in a Project. Memory stays general.

OPTION 2 — Use Incognito chats for sensitive business work

Click the ghost icon in a new chat to start an Incognito conversation. Incognito chats are not saved to history, do not contribute to Memory, and disappear when the session closes.

OPTION 3 — Review Memory weekly, not quarterly

If you prefer to work in standalone chats, treat Memory audit as a weekly task. Settings → Memory → delete anything that belongs to one business and has leaked into the general profile.

What never to let Memory hold

- Client-identifiable information
- Regulated data (financial, medical, legal matters)
- Anything covered by an NDA
- Passwords, API keys, or credentials (never paste these anywhere in chat regardless)

3. Profile Preferences template

Paste this into Settings → Profile → ‘What personal preferences should Claude consider in responses?’ Fill in the brackets. Keep it under 500 words total (Primett, 2026).

> **SET IT ONCE.** You paste this into Claude’s settings one time. From that moment on, Claude loads it into a new chat automatically. You do not re-paste it, copy it into conversations, or do anything else with it. Update it when your role or preferences change.

Template (copy and fill in)

> **ABOUT ME**

I am a [ROLE] working in [INDUSTRY / SECTOR].

My audience or clients are [WHO YOU SERVE].

I communicate in [BRITISH / AMERICAN / OTHER] English.

> **HOW I WANT CLAUDE TO WORK**

Lead with the conclusion. Details after.

Be concise. No preamble. No ‘Great question’ or ‘Certainly’.

Push back on me when I am wrong. Do not flatter.

Ask one clarifying question when context is missing. Do not assume.

For anything time-sensitive or fact-based, search the web before answering.

> **WHAT TO AVOID**

Do not hedge unless the uncertainty is genuine.

Do not use emojis in professional output.

Do not over-structure. No headers for short answers.

Do not rewrite my voice when editing. Keep what I wrote, improve the clarity.

Filled-in example

Below is what a real filled-in version looks like. Use it as a reference for tone and level of detail.

> **EXAMPLE — A performance coach**

I am a Performance Coach and AI Educator. I work with mid-level leaders and business owners. My audience is professionals who are competent but overstretched- they want clarity, not inspiration theatre. I write in British English.

Lead with the conclusion. Details after. Be concise. No preamble. Push back when I am wrong -I would rather be challenged than flattered. Ask one clarifying question when context is missing.

For anything current, search the web. Do not hedge unless uncertainty is real. Do not use emojis in client-facing output. Do not rewrite my voice when you edit.

4. Project setup template

A Project is a dedicated workspace with its own instructions and its own uploaded files. Create one per business, client, or recurring workstream (Anthropic, 2026b; Hodges, 2026b).

What to put in Project Instructions

- The business name, tagline, and what it does
- Who the clients are (one sentence)
- The tone and language rules specific to this business
- What Claude should always check or reference (e.g. the uploaded brand doc)
- What Claude should never do in this context

What to upload to Project Knowledge

- Brand guidelines or style guide
- Your core offer or service description
- Client personas or ideal client profile
- Recent examples of your best work in that voice
- Pricing, packages, or structure documents

Template (copy and fill in)

> **PROJECT INSTRUCTIONS**

This Project is for [BUSINESS NAME], which [ONE-LINE DESCRIPTION].

Our clients are [WHO THEY ARE AND WHAT THEY NEED].

Our tone is [DESCRIBE: e.g. warm and direct, no jargon].

Always reference [NAME OF UPLOADED BRAND DOC] for voice and messaging.

Never [WHAT TO AVOID: e.g. use competitor names, discuss pricing in marketing copy, assume a technical audience].

Filled-in example

EXAMPLE — A coaching business Project

This Project is for Leaderize, a leadership development practice helping mid-level leaders move from firefighting to flow.

Our clients are operational leaders- heads of department, directors, founders with teams - who are competent but overstretched. They want clarity, not inspiration.

Our tone is warm, direct, and quietly confident. No hype. No corporate jargon. British English.

Always reference the Brand Reference deck for voice. Always apply Minto pyramid structure to any strategic document.

Never use emojis in client-facing output. Never write inspirational generic openers. Never pad responses - lead with the answer.

5. Two worked examples

Two real setups, side by side. One single-business, one multi-business. Same tool, two very different structures.

Example A: Single business (a consultant)

Sarah, independent management consultant. One business. One audience.

Profile Preferences

- Role, industry, audience all included here - because everything she does is for this business
- Communication style: direct, evidence-led, no hedging

- Push-back rule: ‘Challenge my recommendations. I need the stress-test, not the applause’
- British English, no emojis, search the web for anything current

Memory

- On. Quarterly review. Sarah benefits from Claude remembering her clients, projects, and writing preferences

Projects

- Project 1: Client Work - with current engagement docs, SoWs, and meeting notes
- Project 2: Content Pipeline - with brand guide, past LinkedIn posts, voice samples
- Project 3: New Business - with pitch templates, pricing, ICP profile

Result: Preferences carry her identity. Memory remembers her working style. Projects carry the context for each workstream.

Example B: Multi-business owner

James, owns two ventures: a B2B SaaS company and a property investment business. Two audiences. Two tones.

Profile Preferences

- Identity-neutral. No mention of either business.
- Only things true across both: ‘Lead with the conclusion. Challenge me when I am wrong. Search the web for anything current. British English. No emojis’
- Working style rules that apply regardless of which business he is in

Memory

- Reviewed weekly, not quarterly - to catch any leakage between businesses
- Most business-specific work done inside Projects, which have isolated memory
- Sensitive or decision-stage work done in Incognito mode

Projects

- Project 1: SaaS Business -instructions describe the SaaS tone, ICP, pricing. Knowledge base has brand doc, product specs, customer research

- Project 2: Property Business - instructions describe the property tone (more formal, investor-facing), deal criteria. Knowledge base has deal memos, investor updates, market research
- Project 3: Personal - for everything else. Health, admin, family logistics

Result: No cross-contamination.

When James is in the SaaS Project, Claude behaves like it works for the SaaS company. When he switches to Property, it switches too. Preferences stay out of the way. Memory is actively managed.

The key difference

Single-business owner: identity goes up into Preferences. Multi-business owner: identity goes down into each Project, and Memory is actively audited.

6. Nine best practices

Every practice below is drawn from documented guidance - Anthropic's own help centre and the most cited Claude-setup guides (Anthropic, 2026a; Hodges, 2026a; Primett, 2026).

#	Practice	Why it matters
1	**Keep Preferences under 500 words**	They load into every conversation. Long instructions eat the context window before you type a word.
2	**Use 'Do NOT' lists**	Telling Claude what to stop doing changes behaviour faster than adding new rules.
3	**Explain intent, not just the rule**	'Always verify before advising, because my work has legal consequences' works. 'Always verify' doesn't.
4	**Be specific, not generic**	'Start with the answer, then explain only if I ask' beats 'be concise'. Every time.
5	**Stack layers. Do not duplicate**	If it is in Preferences, do not repeat it in every Project. Let the layers build on each other.
6	**Iterate after 3-5 conversations**	Patterns of friction are signals. If Claude keeps missing the same thing, add it.
7	**Separate instructions from knowledge**	Project instructions = rules. Knowledge base = reference material. Do not mix them.
8	**One Project per focused context**	Do not overcrowd. Break by business, client, department, or workstream.
9	**Audit Memory and review quarterly**	Memory grows automatically. Preferences and Projects go stale. Build review into your calendar.

7. Quarterly review checklist

Set a recurring 30-minute calendar slot, once a quarter. Your Preferences, Memory, and Projects will drift. Your business will change. The review keeps Claude aligned.

Every quarter, work through this list:

- ☐ Re-read your Profile Preferences. Any rules still relevant? Anything you repeat in chat that should move up?
- ☐ Review Memory. Go to Settings → Memory and read what Claude remembers. Edit or delete anything outdated, incorrect, or cross-contaminated from other businesses.
- ☐ Audit each Project. Is the knowledge base current? Any files outdated?
- ☐ Check for cross-contamination. Is Claude mixing up businesses or clients?
- ☐ Remove what no longer fits. Deleted clients, retired offers, old brand language.
- ☐ Add what you learned. New patterns, new rules, new context.
- ☐ Test it. Start a fresh chat in each Project. Does Claude sound right? If not, adjust.

Red flags that mean you should review now, not next quarter

- Claude keeps missing the same thing - it belongs in Preferences or Project Instructions
- You find yourself re-explaining context at the start of most chats
- Claude references a client, offer, or brand that no longer exists
- The tone feels wrong in one business but right in another - that is cross-contamination
- Memory contains information from a business or client you no longer work with

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Bally Binning

Performance Coach & Lead AI Educator,
Leaderize coach@ballybinning.com
leaderize.co.uk
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